



Balancing Act

Asin has acted in four languages: Malayalam, Tamil, Telugu and Hindi. She is also acting in an Indo-Japanese film titled *The 19th Step*.

There's a standing joke among Asin's friends. They say that *Ghajini* director A.R. Murugadoss got the inspiration for her character, Kalpana, when he met her. Her friends may not be off the mark. The animated actor talks fast and gets excited even at the sight of a plain-looking *paneer* sandwich that she picks on through the conversation. Even before getting comfortable on the couch, Asin declares, "I didn't sleep the whole night." She's just returned from Srinagar and will soon be off to Kerala to learn the ancient martial arts form, Kalaripayattu, for an English-Japanese film, *The 19th Step*. "I've been working non-stop on my advertisements and photo shoots," says the 23-year-old.

The fact that she has only one Hindi film, *London Dreams*, in her bag right now doesn't worry her. The girl from Ernakulam has had the camera on her since she was 14. "I was a hyperactive child. Someone suggested I try modelling and I said why not," she says. Within two years, Asin had signed her first Malayalam film and within the next three years, she had completed five films in Tamil and Telugu. No stranger to celebrity, Asin says the biggest difference between South Indian and Hindi films is the scale. "Rumours are nastier here. People have commented on how I've bought shoes for Rs 2 lakh when in reality, I don't even like shopping," she says. The teenager who would steal hard-bound copies of Shakespeare from her father's library has now grown up to become a star. And when she looks out of her Mumbai apartment and stares at the ocean, you feel that sometimes even she finds the transformation hard to believe.

by Jhilmil Motihar